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Don’t Cry for Me

‘Oh, you’re the soccer player, aren’t you?’

There are plenty of soccer supporters in England who would rather see their club win the League than see the national team win the World Cup. I can understand that. You follow your club 365 days of every year; you’re thinking and talking about it far more than the England side. Everybody gets involved when England are playing in the major tournaments and big games, but your passion for the team you support is there all the time. When I was younger, maybe I was a bit like that. Even though I thought about representing my country, all my focus was on making it at United. Playing for England didn’t really begin to matter to me, and didn’t begin to seem like a realistic ambition, until after I’d found my feet at Old Trafford.

When I was a boy, Dad used to take me to watch schoolboy internationals involving players who were my age or just a little older, but I don’t think we ever went to see the full England side. In my early teens, I played soccer for my District and my County but I never got a sniff of a chance beyond that. Once I’d started at United, I did get invited for trials at the FA National School, which was based at Lilleshall in Shropshire in those days. I went along knowing full well that, even if I’d been offered a place, I wouldn’t have taken it up. As it turned out, I never had to think twice about the decision: the coaches at Lilleshall thought I was too small for a sixteen-year-old. I do know players—current England team-mates like Michael Owen and Sol Campbell—who went there and had a really good time. But it wasn’t for me. There was only one school where I wanted to be learning my game: Old Trafford. Who could be better teachers for me than the likes of Nobby Stiles, Eric Harrison and Alex Ferguson?

It’s an honor for any player to represent his country. But you can’t make it